



Plan For Retirement

...For your old PC. When you upgrade or buy a new PC, don't throw the old one away—it could still come in handy

Robert Sovereign-Smith

It happens every two or three years, and you've gotten used to it by now. It's like the death of a pet, and it's not easy. The average dog ages seven years to every human year, but the average PC ages twice or thrice as fast as that!

So you've had your PC for over three years and are looking for a replacement: it's time the old box retired. Before you send it away to the big scrap-yard in the sky, why not let it retire gracefully? Give it a chance, let it do some social work, some odd jobs around the house. Let it earn its keep and live on in dignity—it deserves a reprieve for all those months of stable service it provided you.

What Can It Do?

So what *can* an old PC do? Well, pretty much anything your new recruit will be able to—just a lot slower. However, it has one distinct advantage—the older the box, the less power it consumes: using your old PC for tasks that don't require speed and urgency is actually better, because you can leave it on 24/7 and not worry about huge power bills. And well, if they malfunction and die—no big deal!

There's just one problem: whether it's about space or the fact that no one usually wants to keep two monitors around the house, you're going to have to pick jobs that don't really require a monitor to be hooked up to the old bat. We've taken the liberty of suggesting a few in this article, but we suggest you use your imagination, because only you know what you need that senior citizen to do.

Answer That

The very first thing that comes to mind is to use the old PC as a proxy server. Not only will this save you bandwidth, but because of caching, it will also speed up your browsing experience. Regular readers of *Digit* will know that we've covered this very topic in our November 2007 issue, so we can't repeat that—but for those who didn't read that article, it's on page 103 (of last month's issue). We've talked about Proxy+ (www.proxyplus.net) and FreeProxy (www.handcraftedsoftware.org) for those of you running Windows, and Squid

(www.squid-cache.org) if you're willing to install Linux on the old PC. No matter how old that PC is, reading and sending data from its hard drives will always be faster than your Net connection (unless you're in Sweden or Norway), so older PCs are perfect solutions to play the role of a proxy server.

Hold These

Another good use for the old box is as a file server. This is especially good in a house or small office where you have one set of files and multiple people using them. For example, say you and your family members do your accounting and taxes together, so you need to work on the same files simultaneously. The best solution is to use the old box as a networked file server, so no matter who is in the house or which PCs / laptops are switched on, anyone who wants to access those important files can do so easily. All you need to do is make sure your old PC has Windows installed, has File and Printer sharing enabled, and has all your shared documents stored in a shared folder. Remember to dollar-share this folder—share the folder as `documents$` instead of just documents to prevent your box from being infected with viruses over the network. Also remember to install an anti-virus that has a real-time scanner so as to protect everyone on the network—all it needs is one infected pen drive to infect a network.

If you're used to using Unix-based systems, then instead of running Windows, we recommend you take a look at FreeNAS (www.freenas.org), a FreeBSD-based OS that's built to be a fileserver. It supports RAID and can be controlled through a Web browser, so no monitor is required after installation. The beauty of FreeNAS is that it can just be run off a CD-ROM drive (loaded into memory), and thus all your hard disks can be used as storage. With low system requirements, it's a good option for really old computers.

Print That

With home networks popping up all the time—because more and more people have more than one computer at home—network printers are the rage today. However, a lot of us went out and bought a non-networked printer a few years

ago, because we only had one PC back then. Today, with everyone wanting to print something or another on a daily basis, you're probably fed up of people switching on your PC for a printout and then forgetting to turn it off again. It's also irritating when you restart after installing some software and have people yelling at you five minutes later when they can't find the prints they sent. Here's where an old computer can step in: just connect the printer to the old PC and let it do everyone's printing. Even if your computer is so old that it only supports USB 1.1, this really doesn't mean much when it comes to printing; people will just have to wait a few seconds longer for their prints than normal, which they probably will not even notice—unless they're photo-printing 100 MB images!

Sing To Me

One very popular use for old computers is to use them as a rather large MP3 player. For this, your old computer will need to have a decent sound card with speakers connected—you can store all your music on its hard drive. You can use Remote Desktop to connect to it from other computers and play your music if you do not want to keep a monitor. However, this is completely pointless if you want to store the old computer out of sight in a different room.

The best streaming solution for audio over the LAN as well as the Internet has to be Logitech's SlimServer (<http://slimdevices.com/pi.features.html>). This open source software is actually made to control their SlimBox devices, but it can be used by software players such as Winamp, WMP, iTunes, etc., to listen to streaming music. All you need to do is install it on your old PC, navigate in a browser to <http://127.0.0.1:9000/> and start configuring it. It's quite simple to use—just make sure you follow the online installation guide and look at the FAQs to understand everything. The most beautiful feature of SlimServer is the fact that you can even listen to your music when you're at the office, because it streams over the Net as well. What's more, multiple people can connect to the server and all listen to their own choice of music.



Chaitanya Surpur

After you install SlimServer, make sure to go to the Server Settings > Security page and set a username and password to access the stream. You will also need to know your old PC's IP on the Net to be able to connect to it remotely. If you have a dynamic IP—one that

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Biometric enabled Labour Management System...

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